

Common concerns in pregnancy

In this section, you will find a list of common concerns with an explanation of the adaptation process that may cause these symptoms, information on whether medical help is likely to be required, and advice on measures you can take yourself to alleviate symptoms.

General symptoms

Fatigue usually subsides during the second trimester but is likely to return in the third trimester.

Causes The main causes are massive hormonal changes and the extra demands on the body made by an increase in blood volume of up to 50 percent. This increase helps the lining of the uterus to thicken and the placenta to develop. Late in pregnancy, fatigue may recur because your extra size and weight and the demands of the growing baby means that your body systems need to work harder. Difficulty sleeping can contribute to tiredness, and it can also be caused by [anemia](#).

What to do If you are working, take regular breaks and get some fresh air at least once a day. Ensure that your fluid intake is adequate; caffeine is not helpful because it dehydrates your body and will leave you feeling worse. Take more time for sleep if you need to; housework can wait and you may need to cut back on social commitments.

Difficulty sleeping is common, especially in the first and third trimesters.

Causes A common cause of disturbed sleep is the need to urinate frequently. Early in pregnancy, this is due to the amount of blood in your body, leading to the kidneys filtering out more fluid, which ends up in your bladder. Another factor is expansion of the uterus, which competes for space with the bladder. This leads the bladder to require more frequent emptying. Many women also feel hungry during the night and need to snack, while others find that nausea and vomiting interrupt their night or lead to early waking. From about 20 weeks of pregnancy, the uterus moves up out of the pelvis, taking pressure off the bladder, and nausea often subsides, which means that sleep improves. Toward the end of pregnancy, sleep patterns can once again be disturbed. Unborn babies are often active just when you want to rest; your body is bulky and finding comfortable sleeping positions becomes difficult; and as the baby becomes bigger and heavier, pressure on the bladder may return.

What to do If frequent urination is keeping you awake, don't drink large quantities of fluid close to bedtime, and to avoid waking up hungry include foods high in unrefined carbohydrates, such as whole wheat bread, in your evening meal. If you do wake up, don't lie there for long periods, since this is frustrating and may lead to habitual sleeplessness. Later in pregnancy when you find it difficult to get comfortable, experiment with different sleeping positions: use plenty of pillows, under your head and belly and between your knees. A rest during the day is essential during late pregnancy, but limit this to a 20-minute power nap or an hour reading or watching television with your feet up. If you sleep for long periods during the day, you will further lessen your ability to sleep at night.

Headaches are common, especially in the first trimester.

Causes Most headaches are unlikely to be a cause for concern and are probably due to hormonal changes and the need for additional fluids. Headaches occurring in the third trimester that are accompanied by other symptoms, such as abdominal pain or nausea, may be a sign of [preeclampsia](#) and should be assessed by a doctor.

What to do If you have a headache in late pregnancy that is accompanied by swelling of the legs and ankles, generalized body swelling, abdominal pain, or nausea and